The Ingredient Reader

Fifty-three names from the back of the bottle: which come from an animal, which might, and how to read the list they sit in.

FREE · WITH A POCKET CARD · 10 PAGES

An educational reference. Not legal advice, and not a certification of anything.

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The Ingredient Reader

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PART ONE

How to read the list

Six things about an ingredients list that the list itself does not tell you.

01 The names are standardised

Cosmetics are labelled with INCI names, an international naming system. It is why water appears as Aqua and beeswax as Cera Alba — and why a list can look more alarming, or more innocent, than it is.

02 The order means something

Under the EU Cosmetic Products Regulation, ingredients are listed in descending order of weight. Those below one per cent may follow in any order, and colourants may be listed last, in any order, by CI number. Other markets use similar rules; check your own.

03 "Parfum" is one word for many substances

A fragrance blend may be listed under a single name, so its components do not each appear — with exceptions for certain listed allergens. If scent matters to you, the list will not settle it; the brand has to.

04 One substance, several names

The same ingredient can appear under a common name, a Latin name, a chemical name or a colour index number. Every entry here gives the names a label is likely to use.

05 Origin is not printed

Several common ingredients can come from an animal, a plant or a laboratory, and the name is identical in each case. Those are marked "ask first". The list cannot tell you; only the brand can.

06 A list is about contents, not conduct

An ingredients list says what is in the product. It says nothing about whether the product or its ingredients were tested on animals — that depends on the brand's policy and the markets it sells in. For that, look for a named certification.

PART TWO

Animal-derived

15 ingredients that come from an animal, with the names a label uses for each.

Carmine

On a label: CI 75470 · Cochineal Extract · Carminic Acid · Natural Red 4

WHAT IT IS — A red pigment made from crushed cochineal insects, used in lipsticks, blushes and some foods.

NOTE — **Roughly 70,000 insects are killed to produce a kilogram of dye.**

Lanolin

On a label: Wool Wax · Adeps Lanae · Lanolin Alcohol

WHAT IT IS — A waxy emollient extracted from sheep's wool, common in lip balms and heavy moisturisers.

NOTE — **A wool by-product; its supply is tied to the wool industry.**

Beeswax

On a label: Cera Alba · Cera Flava

WHAT IT IS — Wax secreted by honeybees to build comb, used as a thickener and barrier agent.

Honey

On a label: Mel · Mel Extract

WHAT IT IS — Bee-produced humectant used in masks and cleansers.

Propolis

On a label: Bee Propolis

WHAT IT IS — Resin collected by bees to seal the hive; used for claimed antibacterial effects.

Royal Jelly

On a label: Jelly Royale

WHAT IT IS — Secretion fed to bee larvae, marketed in anti-ageing formulas.

Keratin

On a label: Hydrolyzed Keratin

WHAT IT IS — Protein used in hair treatments to smooth and strengthen the shaft.

NOTE — **Typically sourced from wool, horns, hooves or feathers.**

Elastin

On a label: Hydrolyzed Elastin

WHAT IT IS — Connective-tissue protein used in firming claims.

NOTE — **Usually derived from cattle neck ligaments or aorta.**

Silk Protein

On a label: Hydrolyzed Silk · Serica · Sericin

WHAT IT IS — Protein from silkworm cocoons, used for slip in hair and skin products.

NOTE — **Silkworms are killed in the cocoon during conventional reeling.**

Tallow

On a label: Sodium Tallowate · Tallow Acid · Adeps Bovis

WHAT IT IS — Rendered cattle or sheep fat, used in soaps and some creams.

NOTE — **A slaughter by-product.**

Gelatin

On a label: Gelatine · Hydrolyzed Gelatin

WHAT IT IS — Protein from boiled skin, bone and connective tissue; used as a thickener and in capsules.

Shellac

On a label: Lacca · Shellac Wax

WHAT IT IS — Resin secreted by the lac insect, used in nail products and hair sprays.

NOTE — **Insects are commonly harvested along with the resin.**

Ambergris

On a label: Ambra Grisea

WHAT IT IS — A sperm-whale intestinal secretion used historically as a perfume fixative.

NOTE — **Trade is restricted in several countries; most modern 'amber' notes are synthetic.**

Chitosan

On a label: Chitin

WHAT IT IS — Film-forming polymer used in hair styling and some sunscreens.

NOTE — **Made from crustacean shells.**

Placental Protein

On a label: Placenta · Placental Enzymes · Placental Extract

WHAT IT IS — Extract used in anti-ageing and hair products.

NOTE — **Usually taken from sheep or cattle placenta.**

PART THREE

Ask first

15 ingredients that can come from an animal, a plant or a laboratory. The name on the label is the same whichever it is, so the only way to know is to ask the brand.

Collagen

On a label: Hydrolyzed Collagen · Soluble Collagen · Marine Collagen

WHAT IT IS A structural protein used as a film-former and humectant.

ASK Cosmetic collagen is usually taken from cattle hide, pig skin or fish. Plant versions do not exist; 'vegetal collagen' is a different molecule.

Guanine

On a label: CI 75170 · Pearl Essence

WHAT IT IS A pearlescent agent used in nail polish, eyeshadow and shimmer.

ASK Traditionally made from fish scales; synthetic mica-based pearl is now common.

Squalene

On a label: Shark Liver Oil

WHAT IT IS A light emollient oil. Squalane is its stable, hydrogenated form.

ASK Historically taken from shark liver; most cosmetic squalane is now made from olive or sugarcane. The label rarely says which.

Squalane

On a label: Olive Squalane · Sugarcane Squalane

WHAT IT IS Hydrogenated squalene; a common lightweight moisturising oil.

ASK Plant-derived unless stated otherwise, but shark-derived supply still exists.

Stearic Acid

On a label: Octadecanoic Acid

WHAT IT IS A fatty acid used to thicken creams and harden soap bars.

ASK Can come from animal tallow or from palm and other vegetable oils.

Glycerin

On a label: Glycerol · Glycerine

WHAT IT IS The most widely used humectant in skincare; draws water into the skin.

ASK Sourced from animal fat, vegetable oil or synthesis. Labels almost never distinguish.

Allantoin

On a label: Comfrey Extract

WHAT IT IS A soothing, keratolytic agent used in sensitive-skin formulas.

ASK Originally isolated from cow urine; the cosmetic grade is now generally synthetic or from comfrey root.

Hyaluronic Acid

On a label: Sodium Hyaluronate · Hydrolyzed Hyaluronic Acid

WHAT IT IS	A humectant that binds many times its weight in water.
ASK	Once extracted from rooster combs; the standard supply is now bacterial fermentation.

Cetyl Alcohol

On a label: Cetearyl Alcohol · Spermaceti Derived

WHAT IT IS	A fatty alcohol that thickens and stabilises emulsions. Not drying like ethanol.
ASK	Historically from sperm whale oil; now made from coconut, palm or petroleum.

Oleic Acid

On a label: Oleyl Alcohol · Oleyl Oleate

WHAT IT IS	A fatty acid emollient and emulsifier.
ASK	Tallow- or plant-derived.

Beta-Carotene

On a label: CI 40800 · Provitamin A

WHAT IT IS	Orange pigment and antioxidant.
ASK	Usually from algae, carrots or synthesis.

Salicylic Acid

On a label: BHA · Beta Hydroxy Acid

WHAT IT IS	An oil-soluble exfoliant that clears pores.
ASK	Derived from willow bark or, more usually, synthesised.

Glycolic Acid

On a label: AHA · Alpha Hydroxy Acid · Lactic Acid

WHAT IT IS	Water-soluble exfoliants that loosen dead surface cells.
ASK	Lactic acid can be fermented from plant sugars or produced from dairy.

Tocopherol

On a label: Vitamin E · Tocopheryl Acetate

WHAT IT IS	An antioxidant that also slows oils from going rancid.
ASK	Usually from soy or sunflower; synthetic grades exist.

Lecithin

On a label: Soy Lecithin · Hydrogenated Lecithin

WHAT IT IS	An emulsifier that holds oil and water together.
ASK	Soy is standard; egg-yolk lecithin is used in some formulas.

PART FOUR

The rest of the list

The plant, mineral and synthetic names you will meet most often, so that an unfamiliar word is not mistaken for an animal one.

PLANT

Palm Oil	PLANT	A cheap, stable oil and the base for hundreds of derivative ingredients. Also: Elaeis Guineensis, Sodium Palmate, Palmitic Acid, Cetyl Palmitate.
Shea Butter	PLANT	A rich occlusive fat pressed from shea nuts. Also: Butyrospermum Parkii.
Jojoba Oil	PLANT	A liquid wax close in structure to human sebum. Also: Simmondsia Chinensis.
Aloe Vera	PLANT	Hydrating leaf gel used in after-sun and soothing formulas. Also: Aloe Barbadensis Leaf Juice.
Argan Oil	PLANT	A fatty-acid-rich oil used on hair and skin. Also: Argania Spinosa Kernel Oil.
Candelilla Wax	PLANT	A plant wax used where beeswax would otherwise be. Also: Euphorbia Cerifera.
Carnauba Wax	PLANT	A hard palm wax used to structure lipsticks and mascaras. Also: Copernicia Cerifera.

MINERAL

Titanium Dioxide	MINERAL	A white pigment and mineral UV filter. Also: CI 77891.
Zinc Oxide	MINERAL	A broad-spectrum mineral UV filter and soothing agent. Also: CI 77947.
Mica	MINERAL	A mineral that gives shimmer to powders, highlighters and polish. Also: CI 77019, Muscovite.
Talc	MINERAL	A soft mineral used to absorb oil and add slip in powders. Also: Magnesium Silicate.
Kaolin	MINERAL	An absorbent clay used in masks and pressed powders. Also: China Clay, CI 77004.
Iron Oxides	MINERAL	Red, yellow and black pigments used in foundations and shadows. Also: CI 77491, CI 77492, CI 77499.
Aqua	MINERAL	Water. Usually the first and largest ingredient in anything that pours. Also: Water, Eau.

SYNTHETIC

Musk	SYNTHETIC	Base note in perfumery, now almost entirely synthetic. Also: Musk Ketone, Galaxolide, Tonalide.
Dimethicone	SYNTHETIC	A silicone that gives products their slip and leaves a smoothing film. Also: Cyclopentasiloxane, Cyclomethicone, Amodimethicone.

Parfum	SYNTHETIC	A legally protected blend that may contain dozens to hundreds of undisclosed substances. Also: Fragrance, Aroma, Perfume.
Phenoxyethanol	SYNTHETIC	A broad-spectrum preservative, capped at 1% in the EU and UK.
Parabens	SYNTHETIC	Preservatives that prevent mould and bacterial growth. Also: Methylparaben, Propylparaben, Butylparaben, Ethylparaben.
Sodium Lauryl Sulfate	SYNTHETIC	A foaming detergent used in shampoos, cleansers and toothpaste. Also: SLS, Sodium Laureth Sulfate, SLES.
Formaldehyde Releasers	SYNTHETIC	Preservatives that work by slowly releasing small amounts of formaldehyde. Also: DMDM Hydantoin, Imidazolidinyl Urea, Quaternium-15, Diazolidinyl Urea.
Retinol	SYNTHETIC	A vitamin A derivative that increases cell turnover. Also: Retinyl Palmitate, Retinaldehyde, Vitamin A.
Niacinamide	SYNTHETIC	Regulates oil, supports the barrier and reduces uneven tone. Also: Vitamin B3, Nicotinamide.

> **Origin is not conduct.** Origin describes where a substance comes from, not whether the finished product was tested on animals — that depends on the brand and the market it sells into. A plant or synthetic origin says nothing about a testing policy.

PART FIVE

The pocket card

The two lists that matter in a shop, on something small enough to carry.

PRINT AT 100%. CUT ALONG THE DASHED LINE. FOLD ONCE.

FERAL FEMME. BATHROOM · POCKET CARD

Before the till: the ingredients

Animal-derived: Carmine · Lanolin · Beeswax · Honey · Propolis · Royal Jelly · Keratin · Elastin · Silk Protein · Tallow · Gelatin · Shellac · Ambergris · Chitosan · Placental Protein.

Ask first — origin varies: Collagen · Guanine · Squalene · Squalane · Stearic Acid · Glycerin · Allantoin · Hyaluronic Acid · Cetyl Alcohol · Oleic Acid · Beta-Carotene · Salicylic Acid · Glycolic Acid · Tocopherol · Lecithin.

The order is by weight, down to one per cent.

The list shows contents, not testing. For testing, look for a named scheme.

A PROMPT FOR READING A LABEL · NOT ADVICE · FERAL-FEMME.CO/TOOLS

LICENCE

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CORRECTIONS

If something here is wrong, we would rather hear it than not: info@feral-femme.co. Substantive corrections are published in full at feral-femme.co/corrections/, with what was said, what was wrong, and when it changed.

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WHEN YOU WANT TO PUT IT TO WORK · FERAL-FEMME.CO/SHOP

The Brand Audit Workbook	PREMIUM	Audit a brand from the public record, in six modules.
The Claims Desk	PREMIUM	A claims review procedure and working file, for brands.
The Wardrobe & Bathroom Audit	PREMIUM	Four weeks, two rooms, and a list for what you buy next.
The Complaint Kit	PREMIUM	Ask, escalate and speak up, with a template for each step.